Questions: The Inventive Pitch

Analytical Questions

1. Define invention communication as an Active Inference process. How does the inventor act to update the audience's generative model, and what role do the audience's prior beliefs play in determining communication effectiveness?

2. Explain the "curse of knowledge" in inventor communication using Active Inference concepts. Why is it difficult for experts to predict what their audience does not understand, and what strategies can mitigate this?

3. Analyze the six-part invention narrative structure (setup, tension, insight, solution, evidence, vision) in terms of prediction error management. How does each part manage the audience's free energy?

4. Why is visual communication (diagrams, sketches, storyboards) often more effective than verbal description for communicating inventive mechanisms? Use the concept of externalized models and shared perceptual artifacts.

5. Analyze patent claims as formal generative model descriptions. How do independent claims define the Markov blanket of an invention? How do dependent claims specify model parameters?

6. Compare the communication requirements of four different audiences: technical peers, investors, users, and patent examiners. For each, identify the key aspects of their prior model that the communication must address.

7. Steve Jobs's iPhone introduction followed the six-part narrative structure precisely. Analyze one specific segment of his presentation (setup, tension, or insight) and explain how it managed the audience's prediction errors.

8. Why does sequencing matter in invention communication? Use the Active Inference concept of sequential model updating to explain why presenting the full invention concept at once is less effective than building understanding incrementally.

9. Leonardo da Vinci's annotated technical drawings communicated inventive mechanisms with exceptional clarity. Analyze how the combination of visual representation and textual annotation functions as a shared generative model artifact.

10. Airbnb's initial pitches failed because investors' prior models predicted that strangers would not voluntarily share living spaces. Analyze the founders' eventual solution — restructuring the pitch to manage prediction errors sequentially — using Active Inference concepts.

Applied Questions

1. Choose your primary audience (investor, peer, user, or public) and describe their current generative model of the problem your invention addresses. What do they believe, and how confident are they in those beliefs?

2. Write a six-part invention narrative for your project using the structure from this module. Include at least two sentences for each part (setup, tension, insight, solution, evidence, vision).

3. Create a system diagram of your invention showing components and relationships. Then create a before/after visual comparison. Describe or reference both. Which visual is more effective at communicating value, and why?

4. Write and time a 60-second elevator pitch for your invention. Deliver it to one person and document what they understood versus what they missed. Revise the pitch based on their feedback.

5. Write a simplified patent claim for your invention using the structure provided in the lab. What did the claim-writing process force you to clarify about the essential versus optional components of your invention?

6. Adapt your invention message for two different audiences (e.g., investor and user). For each adaptation, identify the three most important changes you made and explain why the audience's prior model requires these changes.

7. Identify the single most counterintuitive aspect of your invention — the part that most violates your audience's prior beliefs. Design a communication strategy that introduces this aspect gradually, building the necessary model updates before presenting the surprising element.

8. Create a four-to-six-panel storyboard showing a user experiencing your invention from first encounter to successful use. For each panel, note what prediction the user would form and whether the next panel confirms or updates that prediction.

9. Analyze a famous invention pitch or product launch (Apple, Tesla, Kickstarter campaign, TED talk). Identify how the presenter managed the audience's prediction errors. What was the most effective communication technique used, and why?

10. Design a "communication package" for your invention that includes: a one-sentence description, a 60-second elevator pitch, a three-minute narrative, a system diagram, a before/after comparison, and a simplified patent claim. Which format was hardest to create, and what does that reveal about your understanding of your own invention?